

Your Autistic Fellow Student / Friend

For fellow students, flatmates & friends — getting along with an autistic university student (roughly ages 18–25).

The one idea

Autism, through **monotropism**, means a friend's attention locks into a few deep, intense "tunnels." University is a *massive* transition, and many autistic students **hit a wall** — burnout, anxiety or crisis — in their first year, often while looking "fine" on the surface. They might prefer text over calls, need a predictable flat, avoid loud socials, and go quiet when overwhelmed. Being the flatmate or friend who keeps things calm, says what they mean, and doesn't take a withdrawal personally can be the anchor that keeps them here.

What you may see — and what's really going on

You may see...	What's often happening
Texts not calls; avoids the group-chat drama	Single-channel communication reduces the load
Goes quiet or room-bound for days	Shutdown/recovery under overwhelm — not ghosting you
Intense focus on one subject; skips "small talk"	A passion and a strength — connect there
Hates loud flats, surprise guests, last-minute plans	Sensory/social overload; predictability is relief
Takes things literally; bluntly honest	Literal communication — usually well-meant

Try this

- **Agree flat norms early and in writing** — noise, guests, shared space; predictability helps everyone.
- **Default to text**, give notice before guests or changes, and protect quiet time.
- **Connect through the interest** — it's where they're most themselves.
- **Check in literally and privately** if they go quiet ("you okay? need anything?").
- **Know who to call** — wellbeing service, mentor, crisis line — and offer to go with them.

Avoid this

- Surprise guests, loud late nights, or "spontaneous" demands.
- Taking a withdrawal or a blunt text personally.
- Pushing them into loud socials or "you need to get out more."

When to get more support

If your friend seems to be burning out (exhausted, losing skills, withdrawing) or talks about hopelessness, **don't keep it to yourself** — help them reach the wellbeing/disability service or a crisis line. One steady friend makes a real difference.

If your friend is a woman

Late-identified women mask intensely and may look like a “sociable high-achiever” while privately collapsing; take withdrawal and reduced tolerance seriously, however together they seem.

About this guide

*AI-assisted, derived from this project's research drafts — the **Family guide** (Part 4), **Growing Up Monotropic** (Part 1) and the **Monotropism** brief. Uses identity-first language. **Informational — not a diagnostic tool.** Fit it to the individual.*

Key sources. Murray, Lesser & Lawson (2005); Murray, F. (2023); Dwyer (2025); Milton (2012, double empathy); Raymaker et al. (2020); Pearson & Rose (2021). Full citations are in the source drafts.